

VOLUME 1 - 07/2026

UNSA's

THE CRITICAL LENS



The Evolution
of War

The Era of Impunity

The Olympics
as a Mirror of
Conflict

Merchants
of War

Our Mission

Dear reader,

In a world increasingly dominated by superficial opinions and depthless perspectives, meaningful and thoughtful analysis is more important than ever. The Critical Lens was born out of the desire to encourage students from the University of Bologna to share their unique perspectives on the events shaping our international landscape.

The main aim of this project is to offer well-researched, nuanced and thoughtful essays and provide a platform for students to strengthen their academic writing skills and critical thinking outside the classroom. The United Nations Students Associations firmly believes that informed discussions begin with the sharing of different ideas, perspectives and reflections; in a time where we are encouraged to simplify narratives, this magazine aspires to challenge this dangerous assumption.

In this inaugural volume, we invited students to engage and reflect on the theme of war. The essays we received tackled the topic from a variety of angles across different contexts. The essays selected for this volume stood out for their depth, originality and analytical cut. Alongside the essays, our editorial team worked on an additional report focused on the situation of humanitarian assistance in conflict-driven contexts to broaden the discussion.

Our hope is that students are able to explore the dimensions shaping our international reality, through these new, student-led perspectives and perhaps through their very own contribution for our next volume...

We want to express our deepest gratitude to our amazing editorial team: Mariagledis Kohilamulla, Oscar Hennin Hetzinger, Giulia Malaspina, Sara Palotta and Elena Lusetti. Their work and dedication have brought this project to life in ways we did not believe were possible. In the same way, this magazine would not exist without the support of UNSA's board, members and community.

Lastly, a special thank you to Germano Gianturco for illustrating the beautiful cover for this first volume. We are thrilled to be sharing with all of you the first volume of UNSA's The Critical Lens.

M. Belen Camperos and Joel Schrader / Editorial Committee - UNSA Forlì

UNSA is the United Nations Student Association of the University of Bologna, located in the Forlì Campus. We were founded in 2024, with the aim of bringing high quality academic extracurricular activities for students, regardless of their background, to enrich their university journeys. Our main projects within our community involve MUN (Model United Nations) conferences, preparatory meetings, panel discussions featuring guests and esteemed members of our faculty, debate sessions, workshops, and various social gatherings and events to promote and enhance the multicultural nature of our student body. UNSA also stands as a platform for student engagement and empowerment, counting with 50 active volunteers, and increasing opportunities and potential for learning and growth. Our team works hard to bring to life new projects that bridge academic excellence and innovation, and it fills our association with pride to present our first edition of UNSA's The Critical Lens. Thank you, reader, for supporting our mission.

Catalina Molin (founder and co-president) and Candelaria Rodriguez (co-president) - UNSA Forlì

If you are interested in our next initiatives, follow us on instagram @unsaforli or reach out to us via e-mail: unstudentsassociation@gmail.com

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Editorial Team

Head Editors

Belen Camperos
Joel Schrader

Graphics

Giulia Malaspina
Sara Palotta

Text Creation

Oscar Hennin Hetzinger
Mariagledis Kohilamulla
Elena Lusetti

Cover

Germano Gianturco

The Olympics as a Mirror of Conflict

Geopolitics at Milano Cortina 2026

Greta Schoensberg

This article examines how the Milano Cortina 2026 Olympic and Paralympic Games reveal the increasing entanglement between international sport and contemporary geopolitics. Through the cases of Russia, Belarus, Ukraine, and Israel, this article aims to assess how global conflicts shape participation rules, fuel public protest, and challenge the International Olympic Committee's claim to neutrality. The analysis highlights how the designation of Russian and Belarusian athletes as "Individual Neutral Athletes," Ukraine's symbolic boycott of the Paralympic opening ceremony, and demonstrations against Israel's presence reflect competing narratives of legitimacy and victimhood. Drawing on scholarship on soft power and sports diplomacy, the article argues that boycotts and sport related sanctions exert mainly symbolic pressure, especially on states already isolated. The conclusion examines the growing irrelevance of the modern Olympic truce, whose failure during the 2022 and 2026 Games underscores the widening gap between the Olympic ideal and global political realities. Ultimately, the Games function less as a space of apolitical unity than as a mirror of a world in conflict, illuminating fractures, tensions, and contested understandings of peace.

Introduction: Sport Is Never Neutral. The idealized image of sport as a space of peace and universal brotherhood clashes with a far more complex historical reality. From the Cold War to the Milano Cortina 2026 Games, international competitions have reflected geopolitical tensions, open conflicts, and diplomatic pressures. The Olympics have never existed outside of history: they echo its deepest fractures. Recent decisions by the International Olympic Committee (IOC), from the suspension of the Russian Olympic Committee in 2023 to the "neutralized" participation of Russia and Belarus, show how the boundary between sport and war is today more permeable than ever, especially in light of the protests and demonstrations unfolding in Milano and Cortina during the Games, including the tense reception given to the Israeli delegation at the opening ceremony.

1. Russia, Belarus, and the War in Ukraine: The Most Obvious Case. The IOC suspended the Russian Olympic Committee in October 2023 for incorporating Ukrainian sports organizations from the occupied territories, violating the Olympic Charter; as a result, Russia cannot participate as a national delegation at the 2026 Games. Yet a limited number of Russian athletes have been admitted as Individual Neutral Athletes (AIN): a category introduced after the 2022 invasion of Ukraine and first applied at Paris 2024. AIN athletes compete without a flag, anthem, or national symbols and undergo strict vetting to ensure they have no ties to the military or have not publicly supported the invasion. This compromise remains controversial: for many international observers and sports professionals, neutrality does not erase the political meaning of Russian participation, it simply reshapes it.¹

¹ Sutherland, C. (2026). How Russian and Belarusian athletes compete in the 2026 Winter Olympics. *TIME*. <https://time.com/7357901/russian-belarusian-athletes-2026-winter-olympics/>

Belarus, considered jointly responsible for the conflict due to its logistical support for Russia's military action, is subject to the same restrictions: no national delegation, but limited admission of individual athletes as AIN, provided they meet IOC eligibility criteria.

2. *Ukrainian Resentment and Symbolic Boycott.* Ukraine has announced that it will boycott the opening ceremony of the 2026 Paralympics in protest against the decision of the International Paralympic Committee (IPC) to allow Russian and Belarusian athletes to compete under their national flags for the first time in over a decade. The Ukrainian Paralympic Committee explicitly requested that its own flag not be displayed, arguing that the presence of Russian national symbols, while the war continues, represents both humiliation and the normalization of military aggression. This symbolic boycott reflects Ukraine's broader soft power strategy: by rejecting the ceremonial moment while still competing, Kyiv highlights how rituals and symbols carry significant political weight, distinct from the competitive arena where athletic participation becomes a form of national resilience. The Ukrainian government has rejected the idea of a full boycott: withdrawing completely would concede the global media stage to the Russian narrative while severely penalizing Ukrainian athletes, who are traditionally highly competitive at the Winter Paralympics. Ukraine views participation in the competitions as a form of symbolic and diplomatic resistance, focusing its protest instead on official ceremonies.²

3. *Israel: Sport in a Conflict Zone.* The Israeli delegation arrives at the Games amid the ongoing war in Gaza, triggering protests across Italian cities. During the Milano opening ceremony, the team was met with a

smattering of boos; limited, yet significant within the current political climate.³ At the same time, thousands of demonstrators in Milan protested the presence of the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) personnel, Israel's participation, and urban speculation linked to the event. These protests illustrate how domestic political tensions in host states can undermine the IOC's narrative of unity and reveal how global conflicts spill over into the local legitimacy of the Games themselves. A few days before the competitions, the apartment used by the Israeli bobsled team during training was robbed, with passports, equipment, and valuables worth thousands of dollars stolen; although no political motive has been confirmed, the incident heightened the delegation's sense of vulnerability.⁴

4. *Boycotts, Neutrality, and Soft Power: Do They Actually Work?* Recent studies show that sports and cultural sanctions have a primarily symbolic impact rather than concrete effects on state behaviour; they often strengthen internal nationalist discourse rather than weaken it.⁵ The literature suggests that sport has become a strategic soft power arena. Take Russia, the imposition of the "neutral athlete" status can limit a state's ability to use mega-events as tools of international image-building, though, they are not genuine mechanisms of political coercion.⁶ Comparative studies confirm that mega-events can enhance a country's international image, but their impact depends heavily on geopolitical context.⁷ In situations of isolation, such as post 2022 Russia, the effectiveness of sports based soft power drops sharply, revealing the limits of symbolic diplomacy when underlying political conditions are unfavourable.

² The Independent. (2026). Ukraine to boycott Paralympic opening ceremony over Russian flags. <https://www.independent.co.uk/sport/olympics/paralympics/paralympics-2026-ukraine-russia-opening-ceremony-b2924221.html>

³ The Times of Israel. (2026). Israel team marches to smattering of boos at Milan Winter Olympics opening ceremony. <https://www.timesofisrael.com/israel-team-marches-to-smattering-of-boos-at-milan-winter-olympics-opening-ceremony/>

⁴ NBC Boston. (2026). Israel bobsled team's apartment robbed ahead of 2026 Milan Cortina Olympics. <https://www.nbcboston.com/olympics/2026-milan-cortina/israel-bobsled-team-apartment-robbed-2026-milan-cortina-olympics/3893097/>

Conclusion: The Olympics in a World at War: A Broken Truce and a Political Arena.

The “modern Olympic truce,” endorsed by the UN since 1993, has become largely symbolic: it is not legally binding and has no real effect on ongoing conflicts. This was evident in 2022, when Russia invaded Ukraine during the Beijing Olympic truce, and it remains clear in 2026, as Milano Cortina begins without any significant suspension of hostilities.⁸ The truce no longer operates as a practical mechanism but as a moral appeal to the international community, carrying no consequences when ignored. This growing ineffectiveness intersects with a broader transformation in the political role of global sport. The Olympics continue to present themselves as a universal celebration of peace, yet Milano Cortina 2026 exposes how deeply sport now mirrors geopolitical tensions. Delegations admitted or excluded on political grounds, athletes competing without a flag, protests against countries engaged in active wars, and symbolic boycotts turn ceremonies and competitions into diplomatic stages. Even marginal events, such as the theft targeting the Israeli bobsled team, feed an atmosphere of vulnerability and conflict. The contrast between Russia’s suspension and Israel’s continued participation during the war in Gaza has intensified debates over alleged IOC “double standards,” highlighting how human rights considerations are increasingly mobilised to contest claims of sporting neutrality and revealing an Olympic movement struggling to maintain coherence and legitimacy in an increasingly polarised international environment.⁹

The gap between the IOC’s rhetoric, embodied in President Kirsty Coventry’s description of the Games as a “beacon of hope”, and the reality of protests, diplomatic tensions, and politically driven demands for exclusion has become ever more pronounced.¹⁰ In this context, the fragility of the Olympic truce becomes a symbol of the widening distance between the Olympic ideal and contemporary geopolitics. Sport does not suspend war; it reflects it, translates it, and at times amplifies it, placing global tensions before a worldwide audience. This visibility, though fragile, grants the Games an unexpected critical function. If the Olympics can no longer conceal the fractures of the international order, they can at least illuminate them, forcing institutions and public opinion to confront responsibilities, asymmetries, and competing narratives. In this sense, the fragility of the Olympic truce does not signal the end of sport’s political dimension: it reveals its transformation from a promise of peace to a mirror, often an unforgiving one, of a world in conflict, where peace is not a given but a contested terrain.

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Merchants of War

A comparison between modern Private Military Companies and the 14th century Italian Condottieri

Ryan Sardi

The resurgence of the Private Military & Security sectors can be observed in a broader historical framework. This article attempts to link the current related market with a historical comparison, the Italian Condottieri - bands of organised mercenary groups roaming through the northern Italian regions around the 14th century. By analysing common socio-economic factors, the article argues that both stem from complex environments, where concentrated wealth, fragmented political authority, and insufficient public security provision are present. Moreover, parallelism can be made in structure, business model and strategic deployment of the two historically compared groups. This analysis ends with a broader observation on the impact of a growing private military sector, and how it can be connected to a deeper systemic shift in the global landscape, testimony of a gradual erosion of state actors in the international field.

Technological advancements, economic and cyber-security threats have dramatically changed the battlefield in the past decades. A trend is resurfacing, predicted to grow exponentially: the private military sector.

Already in 2007 the European Parliament's Subcommittee on Security and Defence requested a study on 'The Increasing Role of Private Military and Security Companies', a testimony to the growing concern about the subject. The market for said services is destined to grow (Kinsey, 2006). The trend is predicted to increase exponentially, with estimations forecasting the doubling of the sector in terms of revenue, from approximately 250 billion to 465 billion USD by 2034 (Custom Market Insights, 2025).

The aim of this article is to compare the fast growing market of the private security sector to the 14th century 'Free Companies' that roamed the Northern Italian regions, highlighting a resurfacing trend that may have deep implications for the international landscape. The attempt is to delve into the socio-economic reasons that might have made

this trade flourish. In order to do so, a brief but necessary explanation of the private military company (PMC) and its historical counterpart will be provided. Furthermore, the article will observe commonalities between the two and attempt to indicate the socio-economic phenomena that triggered a growth in the demand of the subsequent fortune made in the field.

Wealth and Weapons. PMCs and PSCs (Private Security Companies) are essentially businesses that provide a number of services, some of which would fall under the jurisdiction of national armed forces. They offer logistical support, military involvement, counselling, and security services. Their contracts can vary from training local military, to secure sensitive information and corporate assets, to even participation in proxy and state war intervention (Kinsey, 2006). In essence, where professional expertise over strategy, weaponry and tactical warfare is required, the private military sector thrives.

The private security business consists of a

complex framework of companies, security firms, contractors and freelance operators. The field varies greatly depending on the specialisation of each agency as well as the types of contract they are capable of undertaking and their size. Technically speaking, the private security at a museum and specialised guerrilla units deployable in proxy wars are in the same business, although we intuitively understand how they differ greatly. In a similar fashion, the renaissance period in Italy was the theatre of a number of companies that employed a very similar business model. The '*Condottieri*' were a class of organised mercenaries that poured into the wealthy, but divided, northern Italian provinces. Fuelled by former soldiers of previous wars, they formed contracts, called '*condotte*', with local lords of the city-states (Parrot, 2012). The mainstream belief that these were no other than common thugs might be far fetched: the captains were usually second sons of nobility, proper entrepreneurs that created a viable and remunerative business model. As a matter of fact, Mcfate identifies the Italian condottieri, the likes of John Hawkwood, as '*corporate military units made up of international personnel with itemized budgets*' (Mcfate, 2014. p. 76). For example, the notable White Company poured into Italy in 1361, led by John Hawkwood, with a number of internationals after the Peace of Brétigny (Caferro, 2020). Due to their experience in the Hundred Years War, they deployed strategic advantages and formation tactics far superior to other groups. According to Parrot, he '*could offer local rulers an attractive combination of skilled military manpower and new technology/tactics*' (Parrot, 2012. p. 41). This highlights one of the numerous advantages that both the condottieri and current day PMCs possess: well-equipped professionals capable of performing specialised tasks.

This is also true for today: corporate soldiers have been proven to be more efficient, cost effective and overall easily manageable for several specialised tasks, even outcompeting state military. The reason behind the popularity of the free companies, the so-called '*compagnie di ventura*', can be traced also to the wealth the Italian city-states hoarded during the period, especially with trade and banking. Indeed, trade with the orient flourished in cities like Venice, while in Florence, trades and banks, such as the Medici's, took over big portions of the economy. The Italian northern provinces found themselves in a transitional period, where the land-driven economy of the feudal system slowly left space for a mercantilist financial centre. The prevailing societal change in the renaissance was the abandonment of a rigid feudal system towards a more free market economy.

Similarly, this trend is observable in current times with the ongoing growth of globalisation, which could arguably be traced back to technological advances and the end of the Cold War (Kinsey, 2006). Indeed, the European Parliament requested study directly links the surge of PMCs to the ongoing phenomena of privatisation (Bailes et al, 2007). Privatisation, rise of corporate interest, and surge of trade economy are all factors that contributed to the relevance of the private security sphere: the demand for security has surpassed what the public sphere is capable, and willing, to provide.

Increasing Demand of Regional Stability and Security. The correlation between these two periods is rather interesting: the Italian municipalities had amassed incredible wealth, but lacked any sort of political stability and regional authority, and this can be identified as a major cause of the flourishing of the private security sector of the time. Similar insufficiency of regional stability in the Renaissance period matches the phenomena that surfaced after the collapse of the USSR. First, with the dissolution of the communist block, an entire sphere of

power and influence collapsed, leaving vertiginous power vacuums. Second, the response of the Clinton administration was to cut US military spending by 40%, with most of the cuts affecting oversea bases (McFate, 2014). This clearly implied that regions where control and stability depended from the brittle power equilibrium of the cold war suddenly saw the superpowers retreat. Most of these countries had an unstable, post colonial / cold war government incapable of structuring an effective administration or state defence. As with the noblemen in control of the Northern Italian provinces, *'The revenue enjoyed from the sale of strategic resources is also directed at creating parallel military budgets that then pay for alternative security structures supplied by the private sector.'* (Kinsey, 2006. p. 54). As clearly observed in recent years with, for example, the Wagner group linked Midas Resources' licensed contract in 2020 with the Central African Republic's gold mine of Ndassima in exchange for security assistance to the central government. (Philip Obaji Jr, 2024).

Private Security Sector in the International Community. The international landscape has proven to be a breeding ground for the private security sector, and attempting to understand it implies treating it like a profitable business venture. Offering a strong answer to regional insecurity, the corporate soldiers are destined to grow in number and wealth in the near future. The public opinion on the matter is rather condemning, as well as concerned with the ethics, as already seen in the well-documented involvement of DynCorp (American) in prostitution rings in Bosnia in the 90s (Bailes et al, 2007). Scholars on the matter argue that *'There is plenty of evidence that private armies are more disciplined and*

effective than public forces' (McFate, 2014. p. 76) of several countries. The overall evaluation is that *'privatisation of security represents neither an overall advantage nor disadvantage to the international community'* (Kinsey, 2006. p. 6-7). What really matters is the lack of legislative capacity, transparency and absence of democratic overview on the subject (Bailes et al, 2007). In fact, international law is hardly capable of addressing the matter and that speaks for a shift towards a more complex, non-state centric international field. This was clearly seen in pre-Westphalian order, where states were not the only international actors: before the 1648 peace of Westphalia, the state's ultimate primacy on authority and monopoly of violence wasn't the standard (Cerny, 1998). Indeed, the 'international' field in the 14th century was a mosaic of family driven corporate firms, religious congregations, regional alliances, an overall fragmented and complex landscape that maybe can be seen today (Cerny, 1998). The indicator of the rise of private military companies can speak on a broader shift of the global actors.

The erosion of the state primacy as the sole authority in the international order can be seen within the broader framework of globalism and multicultural exchange of people (Cerny, 1998). Indeed, immigration, globalised economy corporate interest, as well as many transnational issues (such as water scarcity), have greatly reduced the national states abilities to coordinate autonomously the international landscape. McFate (2014) insists that governments have to now contend with multilayered non-state actors, such as the UN, NGOs, as well as powerful private companies and transnational criminal organisations. Furthermore, the responses to the increasingly complex intricacies of modern warfare are better answered by a dynamic private sector rather than the stiff national defense structures, leading states to appeal towards companies that can stay innovative with fast pacing technological advancements.

In essence, the concept of the private security sector expanding its reach towards the public sphere highlights a broader shift of power towards non-state actors.

Indeed, trends such as privatisation, surge of free market economies and lack of regional security can be historically tied to the rise in demand of private security, which can lead us to wonder if we are indeed shifting towards a more multilayered world, where state-actors are not the only 'big fish in the sea'.

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The Evolution of War and the Role of Perception of Actors Involved in Armed Conflicts

The case of Israeli Palestinian conflict

Aurora Franchini

Contemporary warfare evolution has led to an increasing attention over the strategies of propaganda and perceptions. The dissertation of Qureshi (2019) "Fourth and Fifth Generation warfare" asserts the introduction inside the warfare domain of the informational and cognitive realm, underlining the crucial role of mass media and the government policies to reduce negative publicity abroad. The ongoing Israeli-Palestinian war represents a coherent case study to examine the relationship amid visibility - and invisibility- provided by media coverage, freedom of information and modern warfare strategies. In particular, empirical contributions are given by Durante & Zhuravskaya's (2018) "Attack When the World Is Not Watching?" demonstrating how engaged parties strategically time their unpopular military actions to control foreign negative narratives. Furthermore, this article is supported by recent Committee to Protect Journalists (CPJ) analysis and foreign influential publications. In a world where information is key, framing the asymmetry between reality and perceptions is fundamental to investigate the erosion of independent reporting, reshaping the perception of what the global public opinion is able to see.

Introduction. Throughout human history war as a phenomenon has been defined in numerous ways and studied by several scholars. From the ancient documentation of The History of Peloponnesian War to the modern news reports, hostilities must be analysed not only as eruptions of violence between actors, but as a socio-economic, political and cultural process, which still characterizes international relations. These processes are mostly driven by the structures and distribution of power. Even though the conventional conflict concept – large-scale interstate fighting along precise frontlines- persists, scholars emphasize a recent evolution which led to an enlargement of its borders. The frequent use of hybrid strategies, asymmetric confrontations and non-state actors' involvement demonstrates how twenty-first century's wars cannot separate different violent techniques from the strategic

manipulation of narratives, identities, and perceptions. The widening of the warfare domain to the informational and cognitive realm, stimulated the creation of a wide database, whose primary objective is focus on media and its role in constructing our judgements.

The evolution of war in the 'Fifth Generation warfare'. Starting from a political economy perspective, the media are not merely a source of information, but they represent a crucial element for delivering policies and enhancing politicians' accountability. Governments' comprehension of mass media has led them to incorporate them into logics of strategic manipulation. In fact, as Waseem Ahmad Qureshi (2019) explains in his paper titled 'Fourth and Fifth Generation warfare', modern conflicts extend well beyond the battlefield and expand their realm, becoming the battle of

¹ Waseem Ahmad Qureshi, Fourth- and Fifth-Generation Warfare, SAN DIEGO INT'L L.J., 2019

perceptions and information.¹ Articles, posts, news and public opinion are the new weapons and the control over foreign representations has become a new strategic objective. As the author highlights, this is a cultural and moral war, which distorts the perception of the masses to give a manipulated view of world politics. This theoretical framework needs to be understood as the operational lenses through which many of today's armed conflicts are read. In this violent arena any means of creating political support of the masses is a valid tactic. Consequently, media and their coverage can be pivotal in enhancing- or covering- a particular policy that may influence an actor's public image abroad. Eventually, broadcast planning can also influence military operations. Indeed, a statement on June 4, 2002, by Major General Moshe Ya'alon, then the Israel Defense Forces (IDF) chief of staff designate, suggests to perceive the confrontation as 'war of ideology' and to consider "... the media factor and the psychological impact of our (Israeli) actions" as part of a wider strategy: "If we understand that a photograph of a tank speaks against us on CNN, we can take this into account in our decision as to whether or not to send in the tank".²

The issue of (In)visibility. Returning to Qureshi's dissertation, he states that warfare hides in the background, and "the most successful [fifth generation] wars are wars that are never identified."³ Observing the eruption and development of contemporary, ongoing fighting- such as in territories of Sudan or Congo - and their apparent invisibility to the public eye perfectly support the author's thesis. The exploitation of popular events to hide unpopular measures is reported many times as military strategies. For instance on November 19, 1989, the Jerusalem Post

accused Benjamin Netanyahu, then deputy foreign minister, of expressing regret for the government's failure to exploit the politically favorable situation created by the Tiananmen Square protests. In fact, the distraction provided by the ongoing protest would have served as a profitable occasion to carry out large-scale expulsions of Arabs from the Occupied Territories. Similar real-world examples of controversial policies that coincided with other newsworthy events include military offenses (e.g., the launch of Operation Protective Edge in Gaza in 2014 on the same day as the FIFA World Cup semifinal or the entry of Russian troops into Georgia on the opening day of the 2008 Summer Olympics).⁴

The case of Israeli-Palestinian conflict. Considering the Israeli campaigns, since the 1970s, the Israeli government has made a considerable effort to project a positive image of the country and its army abroad, a policy known as *hasbar*, making it an adherent example of Fifth Generation Warfare. Thus, the issue of coverage of the collisions in the Gaza Strip can be articulated in many points, underlining both the western media adherence to a precise, distorted narrative and strategies to minimize negative publicity.

First, inside the paper '*Attack When the World Is Not Watching? U.S. News and the Israeli-Palestinian Conflict*', Durante & Zhuravskaya (2018) demonstrate how states systematically and strategically time their unpopular military actions to control foreign narratives. This demonstrates a link between the U.S. news broadcasts and the conduct of Israeli- Palestinian warfare. The results make evident that Israelis policy makers behave strategically in timing unpopular actions to coincide with American newsworthy events that distract the public's attention and

² Attack When the World Is Not Watching? U.S. News and the Israeli-Palestinian Conflict, Durante & Zhuravskaya, 2018

³ Waseem Ahmad Qureshi, Fourth- and Fifth-Generation Warfare, SAN DIEGO INT'L L.J., 2019

⁴ Attack When the World Is Not Watching? U.S. News and the Israeli-Palestinian Conflict, Durante & Zhuravskaya, 2018

⁵ Un conflitto, due pesi: il linguaggio che sbilancia la narrazione su Gaza <https://ilbolive.unipd.it/en/node/22918>

minimize negative publicity. Estimates identify causality between the probability of Israeli attacks if, on the previous day, newsworthy events are likely to capture the American audience's attention. Also, the causal effect is statistically significant if relevant military actions that are likely to generate negative publicity are taken into account (i.e., attacks with heavy weapons, for which the risk of having civilians affected is particularly high). In opposition, targeted killings do not follow the same trend as they are considered urgent and relatively low impact. In contrast, the incentives of Palestinian terrorist groups are less clear-cut because of the countervailing effects of publicity on terrorist activity, and so no estimate is statistically significant for indicating the timing of Palestinian groups' actions.

Second, the article 'Framing Gaza'(2025), the Media Bias Meter Organization talks about "a systemic distortion of the narrative of the Gaza genocide that favours the Israeli perspective while marginalizing Palestinian perspectives"⁵. Furthermore, it underlines the imbalanced ratio between the words 'Israel' and 'Palestine' in the titles of eight different western media, and the same bias is observed in the description of the two actors' actions during conflict- indeed the frequent citation of the 7th of October is used as a justification for IDF tactics while the Gaza blockade and its impact on civilians is ignored. Furthermore, a recent article by Emma Graham-Harrison (2025) explains the efforts of Tel Aviv in obtaining narrative control, impeding the diffusion of materials documenting starvation and mass killings in Gaza. The homicides of Palestinian journalists, the punishment of [Israeli] outlets and the targeting of media facilities, as the Committee to Protect Journalists chief executive Jodie Ginsberg

affirms "is part of a deliberate strategy on the part of Israel to conceal what is happening inside Gaza"⁶.

Conclusion. "Journalists are being killed in record numbers at a time when access to information is more important than ever"⁷ said Ginsberg (2026). Indeed, the latest report by the CPJ denounces both the IDF personnel and policymakers disregard of international law norms designed to protect the integrity of press members. Amid the list of countries where those killings happened, Israel has been declared responsible for two-thirds of the killings of all journalists and media workers in both 2025 and 2024, declaring the Gaza Strip as the deadliest place for the press. Underlining how contemporary campaigns are inextricably connected to a spar over information, clarity and propaganda, the central dilemma on media must investigate the erosion of independent reporting, which reshapes the perception of what the global public is able — or forbidden — to see.

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⁶ (Palestinian reporters killed, international reporters banned – Israel's other Gaza war is over narrative, Emma Graham-Harrison, The Guardian, 11 August 2025)

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THE ERA OF IMPUNITY:

How violations of International law are killing Humanitarian aid

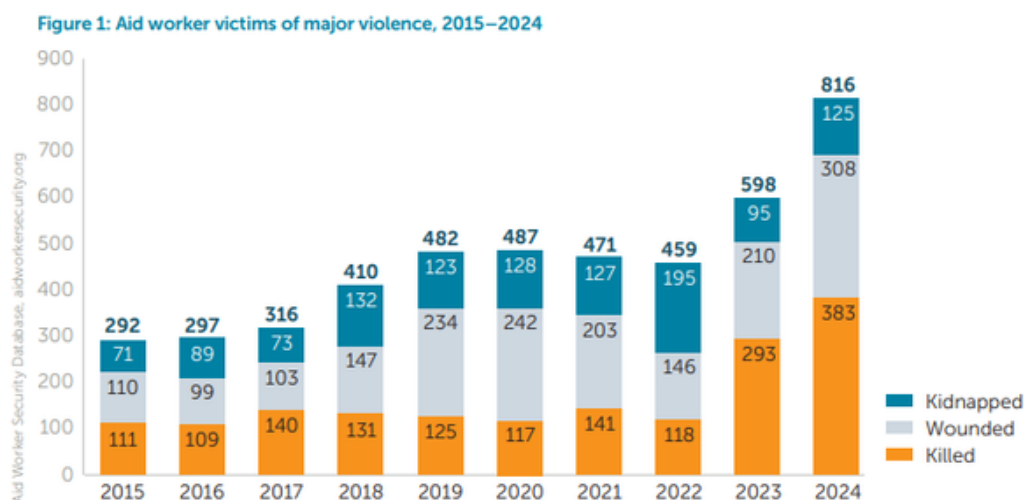
Mariagledis Kohilamulla A.

Humanitarian assistance is intended to save lives, alleviate suffering and maintain human dignity during man-made crises (like wars, attacks, territorial occupations...) and natural disasters, as well as to prevent and strengthen readiness, for when such situations occur. Humanitarian aid should be governed by the key principles of humanity, impartiality, neutrality and independence. However, for several years now, acting in the name of these ideals has become increasingly perilous for humanitarian workers.

In the report of the Secretary-General on the Work of the Organization (2025) it is illustrated that the humanitarian system was stretched beyond limit in 2024. Intensifying conflicts affected the lives of millions and threatened human security. In addition, in the warmest year ever recorded, climate-related disasters devastated communities worldwide. According to UN humanitarian office reports and the Aid worker security database 2025 (elaborated by “Humanitarian outcomes”),

2024 became the deadliest year on record for humanitarian personnel worldwide. During that year, 383 humanitarian workers were killed, another 308 were wounded and 125 have been kidnapped. The wave of violence continued unabated in the first half of 2025, with the number of incidents and victims already more than double the annual totals recorded in most years before 2021.

Tom Fletcher, the new UN Under-Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs and Emergency Relief Coordinator, during an OCHA council, decried that aid workers are being killed at an unprecedented rate. He called on States to protect humanitarians, uphold international law and call time on this era of impunity. These numbers will send shockwaves around the humanitarian community especially on the front lines of the response. The vast majority of deaths are national staff working for the UN, non-governmental organizations, and the Red Cross movement.



1 Diagram from Aid Worker Security Database (Humanitarian Outcomes), licensed under CC BY-NC-ND 4.0.
Source: https://humanitarianoutcomes.org/sites/default/files/2025-08/HO_AWSR_2025.pdf
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“They show the best humanity has to offer and they are getting killed in return in record numbers” claimed indignantly Jens Laerke, OCHA Spokesperson, during a briefing in Geneva, after recalling that the cost of international violence extends beyond statistics: “National humanitarian workers are not numbers or shadows, they are colleagues and friends who act in the name of humanity!”.

The war in Gaza is driving up the numbers but threats to aid workers extend beyond Gaza with high levels of violence, kidnappings, injuries, harassment and arbitrary detention being reported in Afghanistan, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, South Sudan, Ukraine and Yemen, among other countries. The violence against aid workers also reflects a broader pattern of civilian harm in conflict zones.

Despite these challenges and dangers, humanitarian organizations continue to deliver vital assistance, reaching nearly 144 million people in need in just one year.

In response to this crisis, the UN Security Council adopted Resolution 2730 (2024), which mandates the Secretary-General to recommend measures to prevent attacks on aid workers and enhance protection for humanitarian personnel.

What does Resolution 2730 adopted by Security council say? This resolution, adopted by a vote of 14 in favor, none against and one abstention, urges Member States to conduct independent, timely, and effective investigations into violations against humanitarian and UN personnel, to prosecute those responsible, and to cooperate with competent courts, with the aim of addressing victims’ injuries. It also presents an opportunity for the United Nations Department.

of Safety and Security to raise awareness amongst Member States about the essential role of security professionals in supporting the United Nations to effectively help communities in need.

Focus on Humanitarian Emergency situation in Gaza: The words of the Undersecretary for Humanitarian Affairs, Joyce Msuya. In her briefing to the United Nations Security Council (12 November 2024), Joyce Msuya described the situation in Gaza as catastrophic and unprecedented in its scale of human suffering and she referred to the city as a “wasteland of rubble”. Msuya highlighted severe constraints on humanitarian operations: aid deliveries are being obstructed, fuel shortages prevent rescue efforts, and hospitals and ambulances have been targeted. The breakdown of public order has complicated aid delivery and the political decisions, guided by hatred and inhumanity, have critically undermined life-saving assistance. She concluded with a strong call for adherence to international humanitarian law: “Now is the time for the Security Council to use its powers under the UN Charter to ensure compliance with international law and full implementation of its resolutions”.

A one year gap: the new Joyce Msuya’s report on 3rd April, 2025 Several months on, the situation described by Joyce Msuya in November 2024 has not improved at the global level. She stated that more than 408 humanitarian workers are estimated to have been killed in the Gaza Strip since 7 October 2023 (though the figure has now risen to over 560, with the number of health workers. Meanwhile, in other parts of the world, the crisis is equally alarming: in Sudan, at least 84 humanitarian workers (all of them Sudanese nationals) have been killed since the outbreak

of the current conflict in April 2023. Lebanon saw 20 aid workers killed, compared with none in 2023; Ethiopia and Syria each had 14 killings, about double their numbers in 2023.

According to AWSD, Gaza is the most lethal context for humanitarian workers, while South Sudan, Nigeria, Lebanon, Ukraine, Ethiopia, Somalia, Syria, and the Democratic Republic of the Congo complete the ranking of the ten most dangerous countries for aid workers. Airstrikes are the leading cause of death, particularly in Gaza, Lebanon, and Ukraine, while small arms have been the most common means of violence in South Sudan and Sudan. Kidnappings have increased in South Sudan, Burkina Faso, Cameroon, the Central African Republic, Chad, Nigeria, and Sudan.

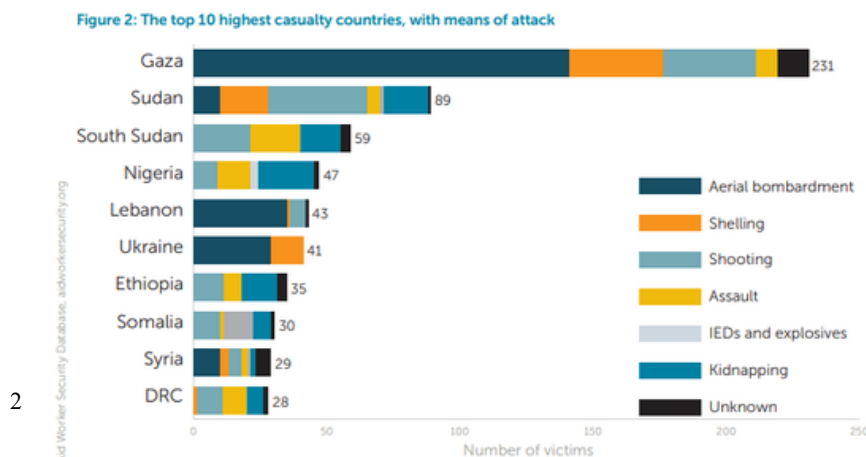
Despite these challenges and dangers, humanitarian organizations continue to deliver vital assistance, reaching nearly 144 million people in need in just one year. But how can humanitarian assistance be secured in increasingly hostile environments? EU and UN action plans to tackle the crisis affecting the humanitarian aid sector: on May 7, 2024, the EU Council met in the 4021st session to discuss protection in humanitarian contexts. It recognized that climate change, evolving geopolitical realities, conflicts and the shrinking of humanitarian space can increase protection risks and impact the safety, rights, and resilience of people in humanitarian

contexts. The Council claimed that investments are needed to develop and strengthen the protection capacity of humanitarian actors and therefore called on EU Member States to provide political support to humanitarian coordinators, national humanitarian teams, and other humanitarian leaders.

On the other hand, the UN promotes adherence to humanitarian principles and respect for international humanitarian and human rights law. It focuses on advancing anticipatory and cost-efficient early action and rapid responses to crises. It also convenes governments, partners and communities to reduce disaster risk and losses. Despite being underfunded and under attack, the UN and its humanitarian partners worked tirelessly to deliver life-saving assistance and protection: of the \$50 billion needed for humanitarian assistance, \$25 billion are provided by donors. Moreover, the UN Security Council adopts resolutions to protect humanitarian personnel and ensure safe access, like the one I mentioned earlier (Resolution 2730), that introduced exceptional humanitarian measures within UN financial sanctions regimes.

Protecting humanitarian workers is not only a legal obligation, but a moral imperative.

If the world fails to protect those who save lives, it risks normalizing a future where even humanity becomes a target.



2 Diagram from Aid Worker Security Database (Humanitarian Outcomes), licensed under CC BY-NC-ND 4.0. Source: https://humanitarianoutcomes.org/sites/default/files/2025-08/HO_AWSR_2025.pdf
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Crossword puzzle

N	U	N	S	C	Z	N	C	D	O	A	P	Y	K
A	P	S	O	I	P	J	Y	J	E	X	D	X	U
A	E	L	V	U	M	Y	B	Q	W	J	I	C	X
K	A	V	E	A	G	B	E	A	I	R	P	U	C
Y	C	T	R	A	A	E	R	N	F	D	L	T	Q
A	E	B	E	I	Z	Q	W	Q	L	D	O	B	N
'	K	G	I	R	A	T	A	U	Y	F	M	Z	V
A	E	I	G	U	C	J	R	R	H	J	A	K	E
L	E	F	N	U	N	X	F	E	B	P	C	Q	J
O	P	N	T	T	E	H	A	S	K	H	Y	L	Y
N	I	I	Y	W	F	T	R	H	M	E	I	P	T
H	N	X	O	C	E	H	E	I	Y	D	K	C	J
N	G	Q	R	O	N	M	C	B	L	G	X	P	J
M	I	L	A	N	O	-	C	O	R	T	I	N	A

Cyberwarfare

Gaza

Qureshi

Sovereignty

Diplomacy

Milano - Cortina

Peacekeeping

Ya' alon



CON IL CONTRIBUTO DELL'ALMA MATER STUDIORUM - UNIVERSITÀ DI BOLOGNA